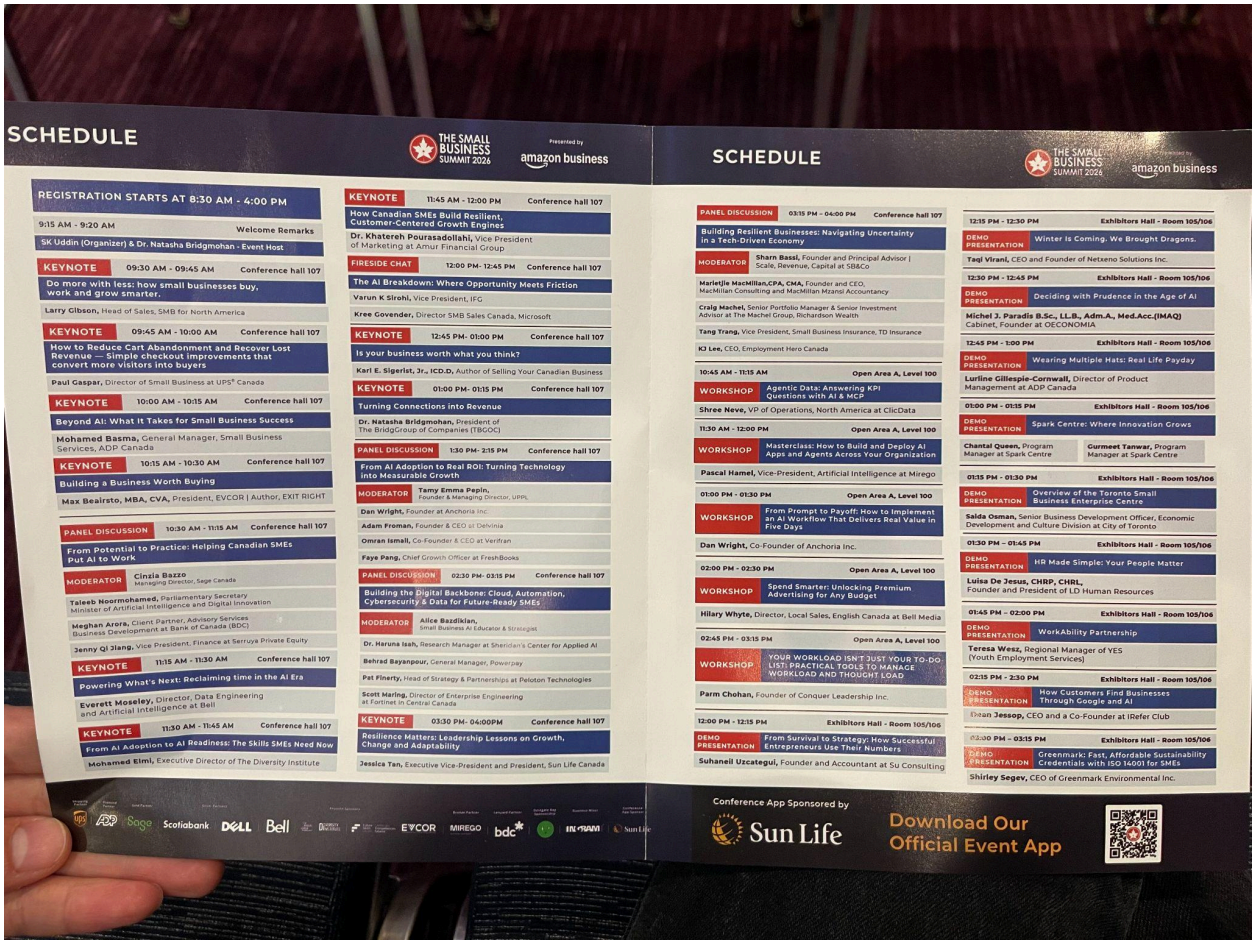
Learning Beyond the Classroom: My Reflection on The Small Business Summit 2026

Assignment: Industry Event Reflection Paper
Event: The Small Business Summit 2026



1. A Rocky Start: The Journey and Getting Lost

This was my very first time attending a real-world tech and business conference. I woke up early to catch the GO Train, feeling a mix of excitement and nervous energy. However, once I arrived, navigating my way to the venue turned into a bit of a challenge. I got turned around trying to find the entrance and wandered around for a little while before finally finding the check-in desk. By the time I picked up my badge and looked at the schedule, it was already around 10:30 AM. Even though the morning started out a little stressful, stepping into the venue changed everything. The energy in the halls was palpable. Entrepreneurs, speakers, and professionals were everywhere, chatting about new ideas. I quickly pulled out the event guide to see what was happening next, and my eyes went straight to the sessions on **Artificial Intelligence (AI) and its real-world business applications**.



2. Event Highlights: How AI is Actually Used in Business

Moving between Conference Hall 107 and Open Area A, I attended talks and workshops that completely changed how I look at technology:

- **Moving from Theory to Practical Work (Conference Hall 107):**
  One panel discussion focused on helping small businesses turn AI concepts into real, working habits. The panelists pointed out that smaller companies cannot afford to waste time on flashy tech gimmicks. Instead, they need practical solutions that solve everyday problems—like managing customer support questions, writing quick drafts, or organizing data. It made me realize that good technology is only useful if it actually saves people time and money.
- **Autonomous Agents and MCP in Action (Open Area A):**
  The most exciting session for me was a hands-on workshop about *Agentic Data* and using AI with the Model Context Protocol (MCP) to answer performance questions. Up until now, I mostly thought of AI as a chat box where you ask a question and get a paragraph back. But in this workshop, they demonstrated how an AI "agent" can connect directly to company systems, read data, and perform multi-step tasks on its own. Seeing an AI act

as a smart coworker rather than just a search bar was an eye-opening moment.

- **Reclaiming Human Time (Conference Hall 107):**
  Later, a keynote speaker from Bell discussed using AI to reclaim lost time in our daily routines. The key message was that AI is not built to replace human creativity, but to take over repetitive, tedious chores. That perspective gave me a lot of relief and clarity—it shows that AI works best as a helper that lets people focus on meaningful decisions.



3. What I Learned: Changing My Mindset

When I work on assignments or tinker with scripts on my laptop, I usually focus on small things like prompt phrasing or code errors. Being at this summit helped me see the bigger picture:

1. **Practical workflows matter more than raw features:** A software tool does not need to have every complex feature to be great. If it fits cleanly into an existing daily routine, it is far more valuable to a business than a complicated program nobody knows how to use.
2. **User-friendly design is essential:** Most people running small businesses are not computer scientists. Developers have to design tools that feel simple, clear, and trustworthy so anyone can pick them up.



4. Final Thoughts

Even though getting lost on my way from the train station was a bit frustrating, this conference was one of the best learning experiences I have had all year. Hearing directly from industry leaders showed me where technology is actually heading.

Moving forward, I want to take what I learned—especially about AI agents and connecting tools

together—and try building my own small automated projects instead of just relying on basic chatbots. This event showed me that technology is moving fast, and getting out of my comfort zone to see it in action was completely worth the trip.